Democrats win Congress

Democrats won the House and the Senate, a result many news outlets describe as a strong message to the president. What they can do with it is more limited than it sounds.

Level 3 · B2 · 295 words · 16.4 words per sentence · 10 glossed · Print PDF

On Tuesday, November 3, Americans voted in the midterms, the elections held halfway through a president's term. Donald Trump was not on the ballot, but his party's control of Congress was.

By the end of the night, the Democrats had won the House of Representatives and the Senate. The Republicans began the day with a 53-to-47 majority in the Senate, counting two independents who vote with the Democrats. The Democrats have now reached 54 seats, and a few races are too close to call. They flipped seats in places that looked out of reach, including Texas, Iowa and Kansas.

The AP links the result to voter anger about high prices, the war in Iran and corruption in the government. Time magazine wrote that the Democrats managed to use a national mood against the president and the economy. The Republicans spent tens of millions of dollars in the final weeks, but it did not stop the Democratic tide.

President Trump said he would accept the results. He said the vote was not a personal defeat, blamed some Republican candidates, and promised to veto laws passed by the Democrats. Senate Republican leader John Thune said his party would work with the president to stop what he called Democratic extremism.

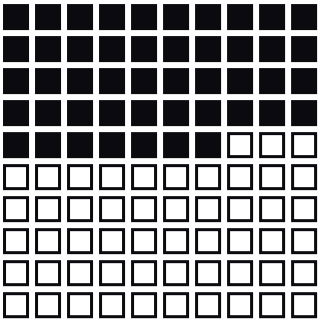
A veto is a real limit. To override one, the Democrats need two-thirds of both chambers, which means some Republican votes. But a Senate majority still gives them power: they will control the committees that can call witnesses and demand documents, and they can block the president's appointments, including federal judges.

The AP expects the Democrats to open investigations into administration officials and to discuss impeachment. None of this starts before January 3, when the new Congress takes office. Until then, the Republicans still control the Senate.

GLOSSARY

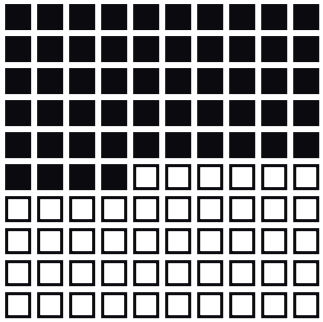
midterms	eleições de meio de mandato
on the ballot	na cédula
too close to call	apertadas demais para dar o resultado
flipped	tomaram do outro partido
AP	Associated Press, agência de notícias dos EUA
tide	onda
blamed	culpou
override	derrubar
committees	comissões
appointments	nomeações

THE SENATE, 100 SEATS



47

Before the vote



54

Nov 4, 2026

■ Democrats (and 2 independents)

□ Republicans

In 2026, the empty squares are Republican seats or seats not yet called.

Source: AP and news reports, Nov 4, 2026. Some races were still being counted.

Two systems, side by side

In the text: the House = *a Câmara dos Deputados*, the Senate = o *Senado Federal*. Both countries have two chambers, but they work in different ways.

	UNITED STATES	BRASIL
TWO CHAMBERS	House of Representatives and Senate	*Câmara dos Deputados* and *Senado Federal*
SEATS	435 in the House, 100 in the Senate	513 *deputados*, 81 *senadores*
SENATORS	2 for each state	3 for each state and for the Federal District (*Distrito Federal*)
TERMS	House: 2 years. Senate: 6 years.	*Câmara*: 4 years. *Senado*: 8 years.
ELECTIONS	Every 2 years: the whole House and one third of the Senate. The president is chosen in a different year, so these elections fall in the middle of the president's term. That is why they are called midterms.	Every 4 years, all together: president, governors, *Câmara* and part of the Senate (one third, then two thirds). There is no midterm for Congress. The elections 2 years later are for mayors (*prefeitos*).
WHO GETS A SEAT	House: each district elects one member. The candidate with the most votes wins.	*Câmara*: parties win seats in proportion to their votes. Each state has from 8 to 70 deputies, depending on its population.
VETO	To override a veto, two thirds of each chamber must vote against it.	To override a veto (*derrubar o veto*), an absolute majority of each chamber is enough: 257 deputies and 41 senators, in a joint session.
THE PRESIDENT'S PICKS	The Senate approves cabinet members, judges and ambassadors.	The *Senado* approves ambassadors and Supreme Court (STF) judges. Ministers do not need approval.
IMPEACHMENT	The House accuses, by a simple majority. The Senate judges: two thirds must vote to remove.	The *Câmara* must authorize it: 342 of 513 votes. The *Senado* judges: 54 of 81 votes remove the president.

Sources: Senado Federal, Câmara dos Deputados, Constituição Federal (arts. 45, 46, 52, 66), U.S. Constitution.

AFTER READING

1. Who was on the ballot on November 3, and who was not?
2. According to the AP, what did voters care about?
3. Do you think the results of midterm elections change how much power a president has? Why?

SOURCES

PBS NewsHour (AP), Democrats win control of U.S. House, in major rebuke to Trump

Al Jazeera, Democrats win Congress: How they did it, and what it means

Time, Democrats Win Control of Both House and Senate in Huge Blow to Trump

CBS News, 2026 midterm election updates as fallout begins over sweeping Democratic victories

CNBC, Midterm Election Day recap: Democrats flip Senate and House

Senado Federal, Perguntas frequentes

Câmara dos Deputados, The Federal Senate

U.S. News, 2026 Midterm Election Results: Maps Show How Democrats Took Congress